

— outspread flight feathers

Fabian's lizard

Liolaemus fabiani

First identified as a distinct species in 1983, Fabian's lizard (also called Yañez's iguana) is endemic to the largest saltflat in Chile, Salar de Atacama. This lizard scampers around by day among the salty lumps and hypersaline shallows, even when surface temperatures exceed 113°F (45°C). It copes with drinking salty water by excreting excess salt from parts on its snout called lateral nasal glands—similar to its large cousin, the marine iguana. The lizard hunts flies, grabbing them in midair, but also takes beetles and other small prey.

Bars and stripes

Fabian's lizard has a big, strong head, a wide-gaping mouth, and robust limbs. Its “beaded” scales—small, smooth, shiny, and rounded—form 11 to 13 untidy, variable stripes or bars of black and sulfur-yellow to orange-red, on a speckly background along the flanks. This coloration fades on the underside.

Particularly aggressive about territory as well as mating partners, males display their striking side patterns to rivals. They also flick their limbs and tail, and clack their jaws at each other.

- ↔ 6 in (15 cm)
- ⚖ 1–2 oz (30–50 g)
- ⊗ Not known
- 🦋 Flies, beetles, other insects
- 🏠 🌱



Chile (Salar de Atacama)

▽ AT HOME ON SALT

Fabian's lizard is active by day among the salty accretions and saline pools. It snaps with lightning speed at passing flies.



△ NOT FOR SHARING

Males will deliver vicious bites when disputes over territory or females arise. Their jaws are even strong enough to draw blood through their tough scales.



△ PERFECT FLIGHT

Gliding at speeds of up to 200 km/h (125 mph), the Andean condor covers extensive distances.